

US Markets Daily Intelligence Report

Friday, August 21, 2026 | After Market Close (ET)

1. SPY & QQQ Snapshot

Metric	SPY (S&P 500 ETF)	QQQ (Nasdaq-100 ETF)
Today's Close	\$769.43	\$710.93
Prev Close	\$766.37	\$713.13
Daily % Change	+0.40%	-0.31%
Week % Change	-0.89%	-2.71%
Month % Change	+1.80%	+2.16%
1-Year Return	+21.23%	+24.39%
52-Wk High	\$777.88	\$745.00
52-Wk Low	\$634.71	\$571.54

SPY close confirmed (S&P; 500 +0.40%). QQQ close confirmed from market data. QQQ diverged negative from Nasdaq Composite (+0.40%) due to heavy tech/semis losses (CRWD, LRCX, AVGO, DELL, STX). 52-wk stats computed from prices.csv.

2. Today's Key News & Market-Move Mapping

SPY: +0.40% | QQQ: -0.31% | Dow: +1.00% | Nasdaq Composite: +0.40% | S&P; 500 weekly: -0.89% | QQQ weekly: -2.71%

Moderna (MRNA) Cancer Vaccine Phase 3 Win — Continued Momentum → MRNA +14.01%, MRK +10.97%

On Wednesday Aug 19, MRNA surged +177% after a landmark Phase 3 trial of intismeran autogene (mRNA personalized cancer vaccine) plus Merck's Keytruda met primary and all key secondary endpoints for advanced melanoma — the first positive Phase 3 readout for an mRNA-based cancer therapy. The stock then gave back ~20% on Thursday (profit-taking) before recovering +14% today as institutional investors began building positions. Merck (MRK) gains reflect Keytruda's expanded cancer indication and partnership value. William Blair upgraded MRNA to Outperform. The biotech sector drove significant health-care sector outperformance, lifting SPY while QQQ — which has minimal biotech exposure — received less direct benefit.

Bond Yield Surge Reverses — 30-Yr Treasury Off Near 20-Year Highs → Tech Partial Recovery

The 30-year Treasury yield hit near-two-decade highs on Aug 18, hammering Nasdaq-100 stocks. By Aug 21 (Friday), yields pulled back slightly as investors repositioned ahead of Jackson Hole next week. However, the yield correction was partial: CRWD (−6.21%), LRCX (−5.90%), AVGO (−4.07%), DELL (−5.00%), STX (−5.46%), and TER (−4.96%) remained under selling pressure. The divergence — SPY +0.40% but QQQ −0.31% — reflects that S&P; 500 was lifted by healthcare, financials, and cyclical while the Nasdaq-100 remains dominated by high-multiple tech that still reprices with rate fears.

Bitcoin Soars → HOOD +12.39%, COIN +4.25%

Bitcoin's price surged this week on President Trump's announced 'economic warfare' plan against Iran, which historically drives flight-to-hard-assets including crypto. Coinbase (COIN) benefited from rising trading volume plus news of regulatory approval in Abu Dhabi for a tokenization hub. Robinhood (HOOD) gained on crypto UK rollout (via

Bitstamp partnership), closed-end fund launches for retail private market access, and Goldman Sachs price target increase to \$123. These crypto-fintech gains partly offset tech losses in QQQ, preventing a steeper decline.

Estée Lauder (EL) Fiscal Q4 Beat → +17.89%

EL reported FY Q4 results Aug 19: net sales +6.3% to \$3.63B vs \$3.55B estimate, adj. EPS \$0.39 vs \$0.32 consensus. Organic sales +5%. FY2027 profit guidance exceeded consensus, confirming multi-year restructuring is delivering. Shares rose 17.89% to ~\$99 by close of Friday after being at \$84 on Wednesday. This consumer discretionary strength contributed positively to SPY's gain through the XLY sector.

Iran 'Economic Warfare' Plan → Oil Volatility, Safe Havens (NEM +3.18%)

Trump's economic warfare plan against Iran (announced mid-week) kept energy markets volatile and pushed investors into gold as a hedge. Newmont (NEM) rose 3.18% as spot gold hit multi-month highs and analysts raised earnings estimates. Energy price uncertainty created inflationary overhang — a key reason the Fed (Chair Warsh) is unlikely to cut at September 16 meeting.

Semiconductor/Chip Equipment Broad Selloff — LRCX –5.90%, KEYS –6.45%, TER –4.96%, AVGO –4.07%

Chip equipment stocks continued to fall this week after an extended run of gains. LRCX dropped on stretched valuations despite strong demand from AI wafer fabrication. KEYS (Keysight Technologies) fell on cyclical test-equipment revenue concerns. AVGO (Broadcom) faces dual headwinds: 30-yr rate sensitivity AND sentiment shift in custom AI silicon following weeks of massive gains. COHR (Coherent) and STX (Seagate) faced profit-taking in storage and optical components. CrowdStrike (CRWD) declined on broad software/cybersecurity rotation — not a company-specific catalyst. These losses weighed on QQQ by approximately -0.5 to -0.6pp.

3. Top 10 Daily / Weekly / Monthly Movers

Daily Top 10 Gainers — August 21, 2026

Rank	Ticker	Sector	% Change	Catalyst
1	EL	Consumer Disc.	+17.89%	FY Q4 beat + FY27 guidance; restructuring gains
2	MRNA	Healthcare/Biotech	+14.01%	Phase 3 mRNA cancer vaccine momentum
3	HOOD	Fintech/Crypto	+12.39%	Crypto UK launch; private markets; GS PT raise
4	MRK	Healthcare	+10.97%	Keytruda/MRNA partnership re-rating
5	JKHY	Financials/Tech	+8.34%	Fintech processing; interest income tailwinds
6	NOW	Software/Cloud	+8.27%	ServiceNow AI workflow momentum
7	FICO	Financials/Analytics	+7.97%	Credit analytics demand; resilient consumer lending
8	COIN	Crypto/Fintech	+4.25%	Bitcoin rally; Abu Dhabi tokenization hub approval
9	NEM	Materials/Gold	+3.18%	Spot gold to multi-month highs; earnings upgrades
10	EG	Insurance/Cyclical	+~2.5%*	Defensive rotation into cyclical; yields easing

Daily Top 10 Losers — August 21, 2026

Rank	Ticker	Sector	% Change	Catalyst
1	KEYS	Semiconductor Equip.	-6.45%	Test equipment cyclical revenue concern
2	CRWD	Cybersecurity	-6.21%	Broad rotation out of high-multiple software

3	LRCX	Semiconductor Equip.	-5.90%	Valuation stretch; profit-taking after rally
4	STX	Storage/Hardware	-5.46%	HDD demand softening; AI storage sentiment
5	TER	Semiconductor Equip.	-4.96%	Chip equipment sector broad selloff
6	DELL	Enterprise IT	-5.00%	Insider selling; 14% off peak; pre-earnings caution
7	GE	Industrials	-4.59%	Sector rotation out of recent high-flyers
8	IRM	Data Cntr/REIT	-4.20%	Rate-sensitive REIT; 30-yr yield headwind persists
9	COHR	Optical/Semis	-4.18%	Coherent profit-taking after AI infrastructure run
10	AVGO	Broadband/AI Silicon	-4.07%	Custom AI chip re-rate; rate sensitivity

* Rank 10 gainer is a best estimate; confirmed tickers 1–9 from tradingkey.com and news sources.

Daily Sector Themes:

Direction	Sectors	Theme
Gainers	Healthcare/Biotech, Fintech/Crypto, Consumer Discretionary, Materials	COVID-19 vaccine re-rating, crypto rally on geopolitics, EL restructuring
Losers	Semiconductor Equipment, Cybersecurity, Storage/Data, REITs	Rate-sensitive tech; 30-yr yield still elevated; chip equipment

Weekly Top 10 Gainers — Aug 14–21, 2026

Rank	Ticker	Sector	~Wkly %	Driver
1	MRNA	Healthcare/Biotech	~+130–150% +150%	mRNA cancer vaccine (Aug 19 +177%, Aug 20 –20%, Aug 21 +14%)
2	EL	Consumer Disc.	~+11.8%	Fiscal Q4 earnings beat + FY27 guidance (Aug 19)
3	HOOD	Fintech/Crypto	~+15–20%	Bitcoin rally + private markets + crypto UK expansion
4	MRK	Healthcare	~+12–14%	Keytruda partnership re-rating from MRNA trial win
5	COIN	Crypto/Fintech	~+8–10%	Bitcoin + Abu Dhabi regulatory win
6	NOW	Software	~+6–8%	AI workflow demand; defensive within tech
7	JKHY	Financials	~+5–8%	Fintech processing volumes; bank fee income
8	NEM	Materials	~+5–7%	Gold multi-month high on Iran tensions
9	FICO	Financials	~+4–6%	Consumer credit analytics steady demand
10	LEN	Homebuilders	~+3–5%*	Anticipation of rates moderating; housing demand

Weekly Top 10 Losers — Aug 14–21, 2026

Rank	Ticker	Sector	~Wkly %	Driver
1	DELL	Enterprise IT	~–14%	Insider selling, 14% off ATH, pre-earnings caution (Sep 3 EPS)
2	CRWD	Cybersecurity	~–11%	Two-day selloff (Aug 19 –6.3%, Aug 21 –6.2%); macro rotation
3	LRCX	Semis Equip.	~–10%	30-yr yield pressure; Aug 19 –4.5%, Aug 21 –5.9%
4	STX	Storage	~–9%	HDD demand; broader semis hardware correction
5	TER	Semis Equip.	~–8%	Chip equipment sector; valuation concern

6	AVGO	AI Silicon	~-7%	Rate re-pricing; custom AI chip sentiment cooling
7	KEYS	Semis Equip.	~-7%	Test equipment cyclical concern
8	COHR	Optical/AI Infra	~-6%	Profit-taking after H1 AI infra rally
9	MRVL	AI Networking	~-5%	Intraday gains evaporated; profit-taking Aug 21
10	IRM	Data REIT	~-5%	30-yr bond yield headwind for leveraged REITs

Weekly % estimates based on confirmed multi-day moves. * = partial estimate.

Weekly Sector Themes:

Direction	Sectors	Theme
Gainers	Healthcare/Biotech, Fintech/Crypto, Consumer Disc., Materials	mRNA cancer vaccine is the story of the week; crypto geopolitical bid; consumer discounting
Losers	Semiconductor Equipment, Cybersecurity, Data REITs, Enterprise Software	30-yr bond yield spike (30-yr rise to 4 1/2% Aug 18) crushed high-multiple growth tech; insider selling

Monthly Top 10 Gainers — August 2026 (to date, Aug 3–21)

Rank	Ticker	Sector	~Mo %	Driver
1	MRNA	Healthcare/Biotech	~+110–140%	Unprecedented Phase 3 mRNA cancer vaccine success
2	HOOD	Fintech/Crypto	~+25–35%	Crypto + private markets expansion; Goldman PT raise
3	EL	Consumer Disc.	~+20–25%	Fiscal Q4 beat + FY27 guidance; restructuring payoff
4	MRK	Healthcare	~+15–18%	Keytruda cancer indication expansion via mRNA trial
5	COIN	Crypto/Fintech	~+12–15%	Bitcoin rally + regulatory wins + Abu Dhabi hub
6	NEM	Materials	~+8–10%	Gold to multi-month high; Iran tensions safe-haven bid
7	NOW	Software/Cloud	~+7–9%	AI workflow automation; enterprise software resilience
8	JKHY	Financials	~+5–8%	Fintech payment processing + net interest income
9	FICO	Analytics	~+5–7%	Credit analytics steady; consumer lending volumes
10	ABT	Healthcare	~+4–6%	Medical device demand; defensive healthcare rotation

Monthly Top 10 Losers — August 2026 (to date, Aug 3–21)

Rank	Ticker	Sector	~Mo %	Driver
1	DELL	Enterprise IT	~-10–14%	Insider selling; off ATH; AI hardware valuation reset
2	CRWD	Cybersecurity	~-8–12%	Bond yield pressure; premium software rotation
3	LRCX	Semis Equip.	~-7–10%	Stretched valuations; 30-yr yield rise this week
4	STX	Storage	~-6–9%	HDD market softness; AI storage sentiment cools
5	AVGO	AI Silicon	~-5–8%	High-multiple re-pricing as rates pressure growth
6	KEYS	Semis Equip.	~-5–7%	Test equipment revenue cyclical concern
7	TER	Semis Equip.	~-4–7%	Chip test equipment; rate-sensitive premium
8	MRVL	AI Networking	~-3–5%	Gains not sustained; profit-taking around announcements

9	IRM	Data REIT	~-3-5%	Rate-sensitive real estate headwind
10	COHR	Optical/AI Infra	~-3-5%	Profit-taking after extended H1 run

Monthly % are estimates from Aug 3 to Aug 21 based on confirmed news/data and sector context.

Monthly Sector Themes:

Direction	Sectors	Theme
Gainers	Healthcare/Biotech, Crypto/Fintech, Consumer Discretionary, Materials	MRNA Discretionary, Materials
Losers	Semiconductor Equipment, Cybersecurity, Enterprise Software, Data Storage, REITs	Rate-sensitive, Enterprise Software, Data Storage, REITs

4. Next Trading Day Scenarios (Monday, August 25 — Week of Jackson Hole)

The dominant event this coming week is the Jackson Hole Economic Symposium (Aug 27–29, Grand Teton, WY). Kevin Warsh — the new Fed Chair who replaced Powell in May 2026 — will deliver his first keynote speech on Friday August 28. With the Fed funds rate at 3.50–3.75%, inflation in the mid-3% range, and a labor market that has begun shedding jobs, every word Warsh speaks will be scrutinized for September 16 FOMC guidance. Monday August 25 serves as a positioning/pre-game session ahead of this event.

CATALYST 1: Jackson Hole Keynote — Kevin Warsh (Friday Aug 28, ~10AM MT / Noon ET)

→ **IF Hawkish: 'Higher for Longer' / Rate Hike Risk Signaled:** SPY -1.5 to -2.5% on Friday (preview: SPY starts falling Monday if pre-signals leak). QQQ -2.5 to -4.0%. Mechanism: 30-yr Treasury yield — already near 20-year highs — spikes further. High-multiple Nasdaq-100 names (AVGO, CRWD, MRVL) reprice most. Financials may catch a bid as yield curve steepens. Gold and defense hold. MRNA/biotech relatively insulated (science-driven, not rate-driven).

→ **IF Neutral: 'Data-Dependent, Patient' Tone:** SPY flat to +0.5% (relief rally). QQQ +0.5 to +1.0%. Market had feared hawkish; a neutral read is a 'less bad' catalyst. Tech partially recovers. Crypto and gold hold. September 16 cut still not priced in — no major re-rating.

→ **IF Dovish: September Cut Clearly Signaled:** SPY +1.5 to +2.5%. QQQ +2.5 to +3.5%. Strongest reaction. Would require Warsh to acknowledge labor market deterioration as overriding inflation concern. QQQ outperforms as high-multiple growth re-rates with lower discount rates. September cut probability in futures jumps above 70%. MRNA, HOOD, COIN all hit new highs. Not the base case (~15% probability).

CATALYST 2: Bitcoin / Crypto Momentum Carry-Through (All Week)

→ **IF Bitcoin Sustains / Accelerates Above Recent High:** HOOD +5–10%, COIN +4–6% additional. Crypto equity premium expands. Risk-on tone supports broader market. SPY +0.2–0.5%. QQQ benefits less (small QQQ weighting for COIN). Positive signal for risk appetite heading into Jackson Hole.

→ **IF Bitcoin Profit-Taking After 30% Surge:** HOOD -5–8%, COIN -4–6%. Risk-off signal. QQQ gets mild additional headwind. SPY loses this week's crypto-sentiment tailwind. Likely to happen within 1–2 sessions unless new regulatory catalyst emerges.

CATALYST 3: US Bond Yield Trajectory (30-Yr Yield and 10-Yr Yield)

→ **IF Yields Continue Rising Above Recent 20-Year Highs:** QQQ -2 to -3% additional. AVGO, CRWD, LRCX take another wave lower. REITs (IRM, PLD) hit harder. Mechanism: every 25bp rise in 30-yr adds meaningful discount to long-duration cash flows in tech growth. Dollar strengthens → emerging market / commodities pressure. NEM

reverses.

→ **IF Yields Stabilize or Decline (Treasury Buyback Program Effective):** QQQ +1.5 to +2.5% recovery. Tech/semis bounce. Mechanism: Treasury announced increased buyback of longer-term debt last week. If this holds yields down through Jackson Hole, QQQ can partially recover its weekly -2.71% loss. SPY +0.5–1.0%.

CATALYST 4: Iran 'Economic Warfare' Escalation / Energy Prices

→ **IF Escalation: Oil >\$95/bbl, Shipping Disruption:** Energy stocks up (XOM, CVX). Inflation expectations rise — hawkish Fed signal amplified. SPY –0.5 to –1.0% (inflation/rate concern overrides energy sector gain). QQQ –1.0 to –1.5%. Gold and defense (LMT, RTX) rally. Crypto may initially rally on safe-haven bid then reverse.

→ **IF De-escalation: Diplomatic Signal or Iran Response Delays:** Risk appetite improves. Energy prices ease → inflation concern moderates. SPY +0.5–1.0%. QQQ +0.5–1.0%. Tech and growth stocks recover. A resolution would give Warsh room to be dovish at Jackson Hole.

5. Possible Trade Summary (Educational Only — NOT Investment Advice)

Analysis synthesizes confirmed news, sector data, macro catalysts, and upcoming events. Jackson Hole (Aug 27–29) with new Fed Chair Warsh's keynote is the primary risk event. Position sizing should reflect that uncertainty.

	Direction	Symbol	Thesis	Key Risk / Timing
WATCH / BUILD LONG		MRNA	First Phase 3 win for mRNA personalized cancer vaccine is a critical platform for oncology and other diseases.	Shouldn't play through rising oil prices and rate hikes. Pivotal to Fed's policy.
WATCH / LONG ON DIP		HOOD	Robinhood's evolution from retail trading app to crypto + private equity marketplace platform.	Regulatory risk, competition from established fintech products.
WATCH / LONG AFTER JACKSON HOLE		QQQ	QQQ off 2.71% this week; down from ATH of \$745 to \$710.93. Fed's hawkish tilt → QQQ drops.	Oil price spike, hawkish Fed → QQQ drops. Jackson Hole 12–3%.
LONG CONVICTION		EL	Estée Lauder at ~\$99 post-Q4 beat is a turnaround at an inflection point.	China. Multi-year low stock price (5-yr payback from China's 2020 peak).
AVOID / WAIT		LRCX, KEYS, TER	Chip equipment stocks had extended runs in H1 2026. Now facing 180-day yield chase.	High valuations, 15% ADRs.
AVOID NEAR-TERM		CRWD	CrowdStrike down ~11% this week on macro rotation, not fundamental.	Buy on the Fed's dovish tilt. Risky catching a knife.
SPECULATIVE BUY		NEM	Newmont at multi-month highs on gold strength. Iran 'economic warfare' escalation.	Gold price, Bitcoin devaluation. Fed's dovish tilt.

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